



## Building Resilient 9-1-1 Systems:

### The First Interstate Backup Partnership for 9-1-1 Calls

# **First Interstate 9-1-1 Backup System**



**Fairfax County, Virginia & Metro Nashville-Davidson County, Tennessee**

# Interstate 9-1-1 Backup Partnership



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# Why This Matters

**9-1-1 cannot fail** — even when everything else does

**Outages happen:** storms, cyber attacks, system failures

**Seconds matter** — delays cost lives

**Public trust** requires uninterrupted access

**Resiliency** must extend beyond borders



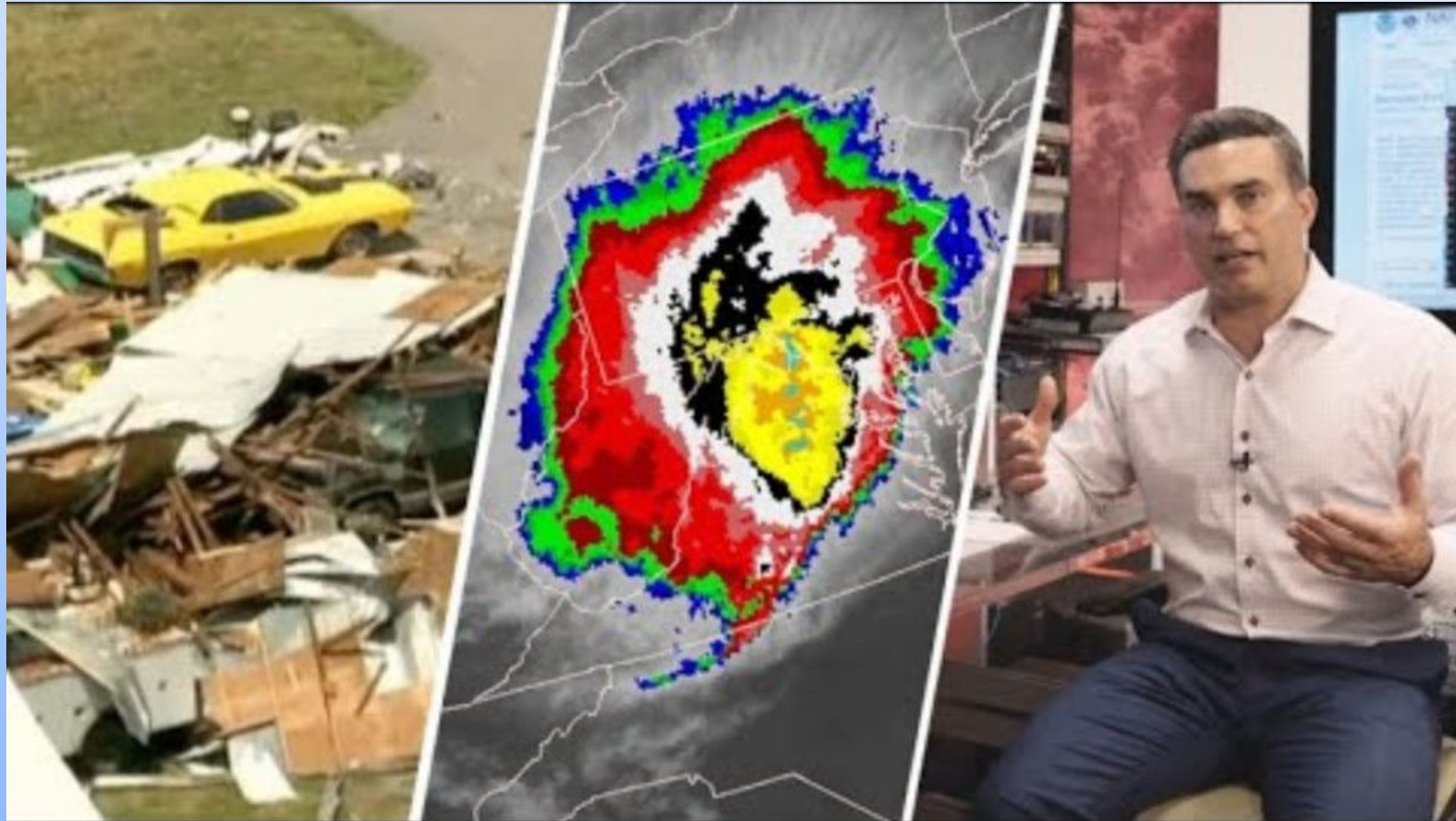
# From Conversation to Innovation



- ✓ 🌐 Geographic Separation
- ✓ 🔄 Continuity
- ✓ 🛡️ Resilience
- ✓ ⚡ Recovery
- ✓ 🤝 Public Confidence

# Real-World Drivers

## 2012 Derecho — A Wake-Up Call



Source: "NBC Washington Rewind: The 2012 Derecho | NBC4 Washington," YouTube.

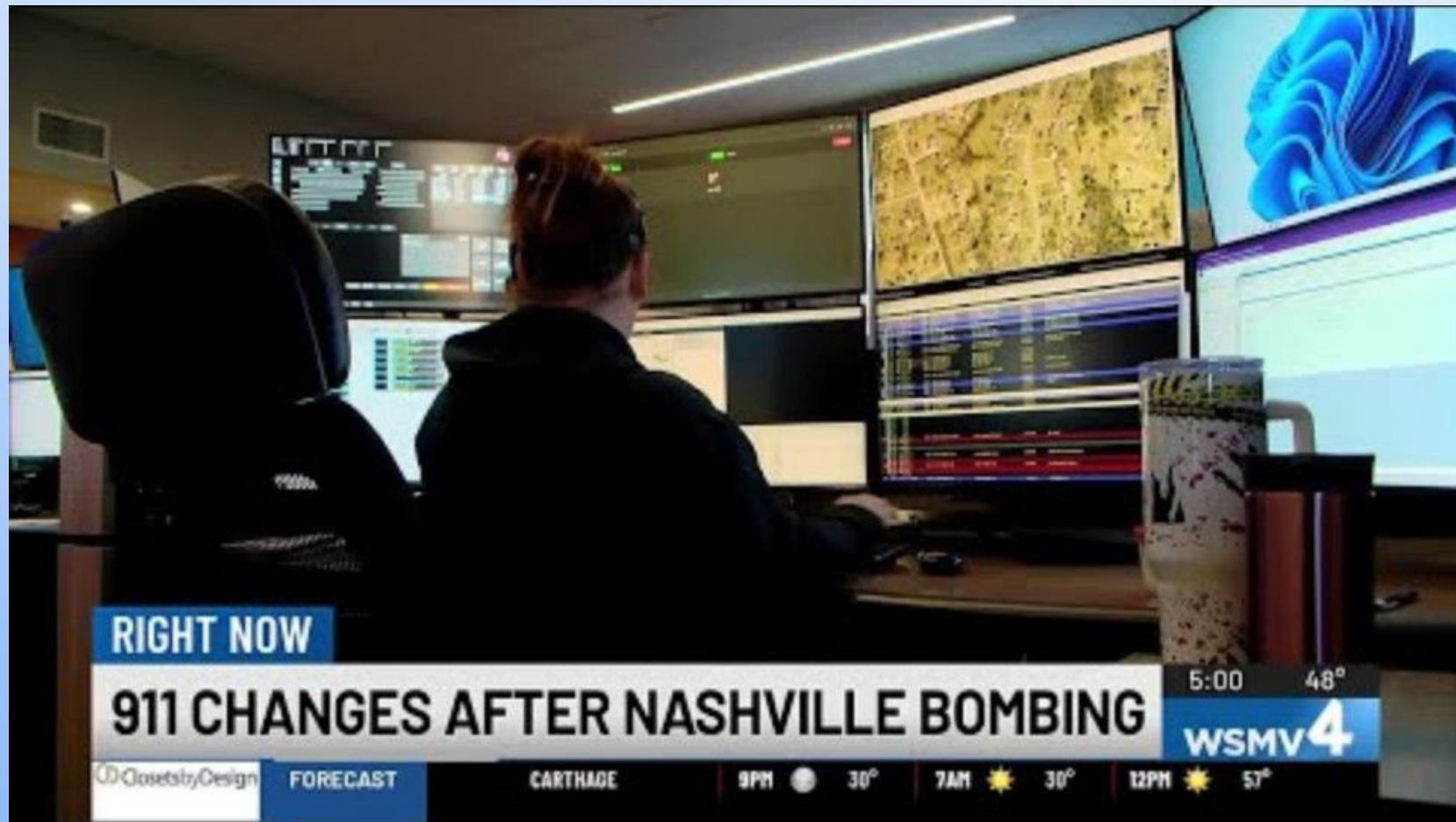
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# Real-World Drivers

## 2019 Nashville Christmas Day Bombing



Source: "Nashville 911 center adds backup systems after Christmas Day bombing knocked out service," YouTube.

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# Real-World Drivers

Massachusetts statewide 9-1-1 outage (2024)



Source: "911 outage in Massachusetts caused by firewall problem," YouTube

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# Formalizing the Partnership



Mutual Aid Agreement established



Shared NG9-1-1 infrastructure



Cloud CAD interoperability



Cross-jurisdiction data exchange



# Why Interstate Backup Is Different

Traditional mutual aid is reactive

EMAC requires gubernatorial approval

**9-1-1 cannot wait**

Seconds matter

# What is EMAC?



NATIONWIDE DISASTER  
MUTUAL AID COMPACT



ENABLES INTERSTATE  
RESOURCE SHARING



REQUIRES FORMAL  
ACTIVATION



DESIGNED FOR  
DISASTERS — NOT REAL-  
TIME CALL HANDLING



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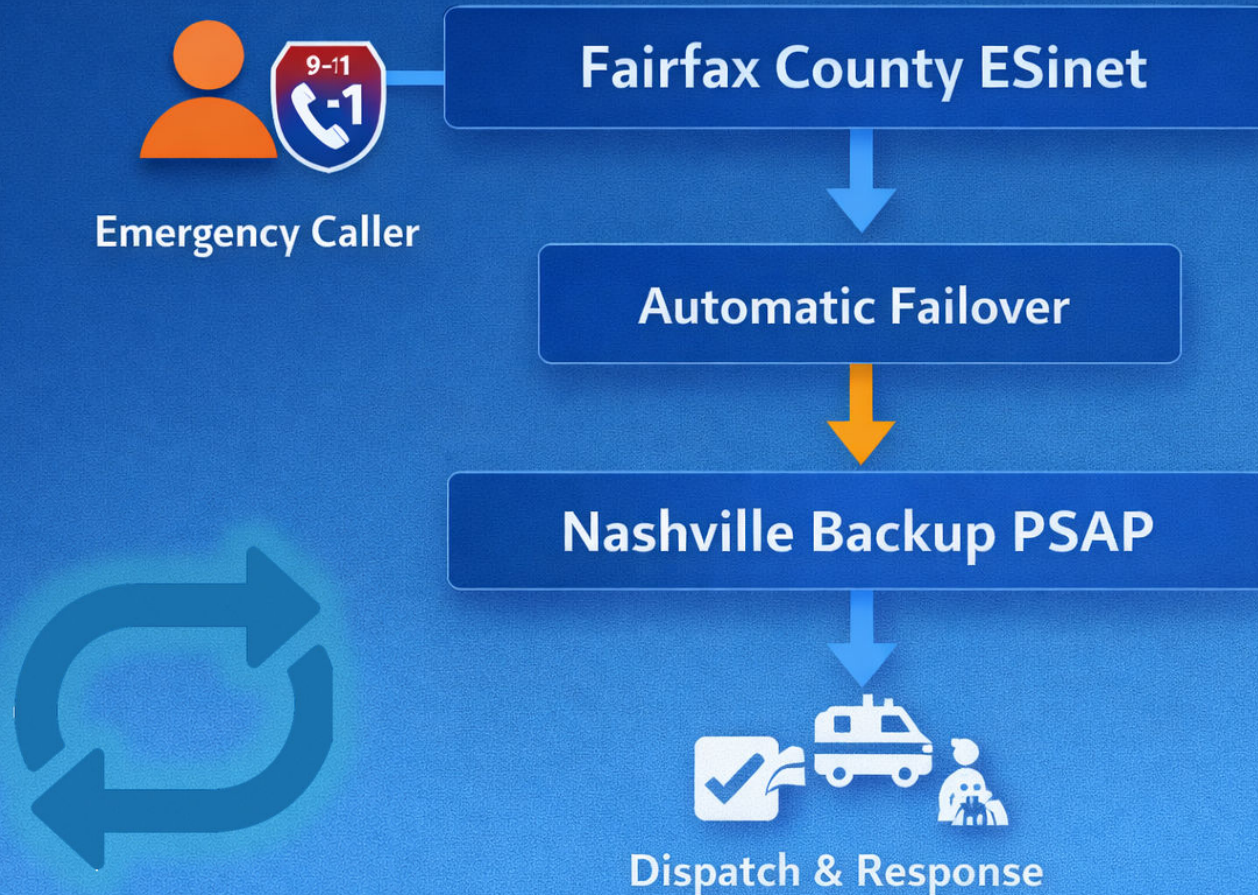




# The Interstate Backup Solution



# Automatic Interstate Call Continuity



# Technology as the Enabler



**NG9-1-1  
IP INFRASTRUCTURE**



**GIS FOR  
ACCURATE  
LOCATION**



**CAD  
INTEROPERABILITY**



# Why Fairfax & Nashville Work



**LARGE, URBAN  
POPULATIONS**



**HIGH CALL VOLUMES**



**STRONG PUBLIC  
SAFETY  
INFRASTRUCTURE**

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# Fairfax vs. Nashville 9-1-1 Comparison



- Population: **1.15 Million**
- Annual 9-1-1 Calls: **400,000+**
- **Primary 9-1-1 Center**
- **NG9-1-1 & CAD/GIS**
- *Local Challenges & Solutions*



- Population: **700,000**
- Annual 9-1-1 Calls: **250,000+**
- **Dedicated Backup Center**
- **Interoperability Systems**
- **Disaster Preparedness Strategies**



**Same Call. Same Care.**

**“The caller  
should  
never know.”**

**Redundancy**

**Reliability**

**Public  
confidence**

**Replicable  
national  
model**

# **What This Partnership Delivers**

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## Lessons Learned:

Technology enabled it — relationships made it work.



Relationships and trust matter



Address legal and policy issues early



Procedures are as important as technology



Geographic separation strengthens resiliency



# Looking Ahead



Regional networks

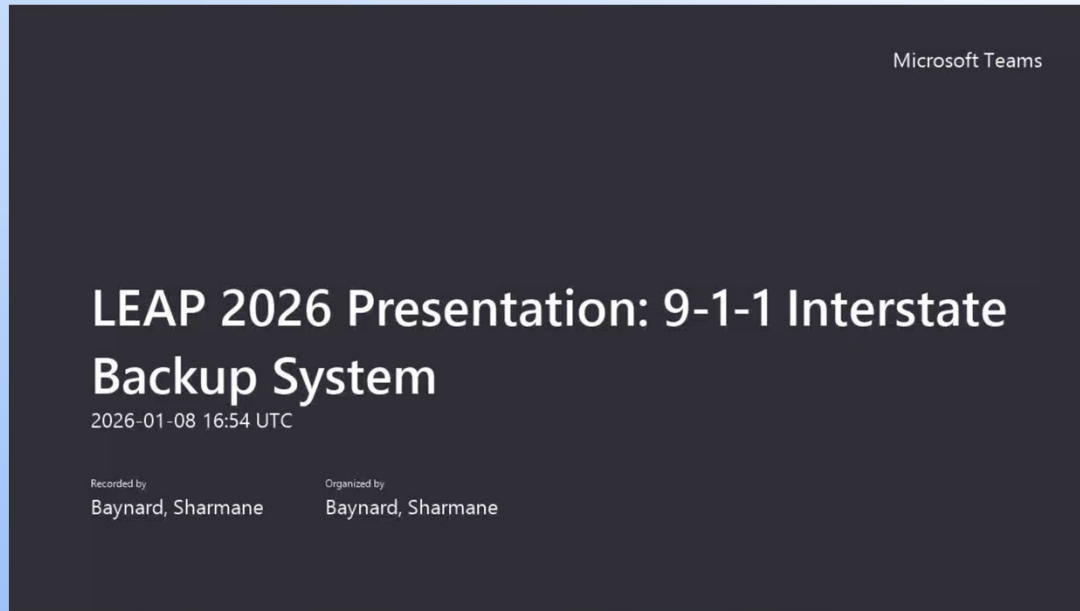


Multi-state  
partnerships



Future-ready 9-1-1  
systems

# A Message from DPSC's Director



Department of Public Safety  
Communications aka Fairfax  
9-1-1 Director, Scott Brillman

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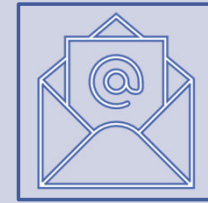
# Thank You!



**QUESTIONS &  
DISCUSSION**



**CONNECT ON  
LINKEDIN**



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# Sources & Citations

Fairfax County News Center. (Feb 6, 2025). *County 9-1-1 launches first interstate backup system in the United States*. Fairfax County, VA: Official News. Retrieved from <https://www.fairfaxcounty.gov/news/county-9-1-1-launches-first-interstate-backup-system-united-states>



Federal Emergency Management Agency. *Emergency Management Assistance Compact (EMAC) overview for the National Response Framework (NRF)* (PDF). U.S. Department of Homeland Security. Retrieved from <https://www.fema.gov/pdf/emergency/nrf/EMACOverviewForNRF.pdf>



U.S. Census Bureau QuickFacts (2024); Fairfax County & Metro Nashville Emergency Communications publications.



# Data Sources & Methodology

## Demographic Data

- U.S. Census Bureau — *QuickFacts Population Estimates (2023–2024)*
- Fairfax County, Virginia
- Nashville–Davidson Metropolitan Government, Tennessee

## Emergency Communications Information

- Fairfax County Department of Public Safety Communications publications
- Metro Nashville Department of Emergency Communications materials
- Public agency operational documentation and program briefings

## Technical & Operational Context

- NG9-1-1 industry standards (NENA & APCO guidance)
- GIS and CAD integration practices based on operational implementation experience

## Methodology

- Comparative case-study approach
- Public demographic data combined with operational workflow analysis
- Metrics normalized for conceptual comparison (not performance benchmarking)